

CELEBRATING BIRSA West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee at the icon's birth anniversary celebration in Jhargram, Nov. 15; Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren in Ranchi

parties deploy. Then comes symbolism—or tokenism, as critics would say. After Jharkhand in 2019, the BJP erred just once more—in Bengal, 2021. Fighting with the Jai Shri Ram chanting brigade as the vanguard, the party lost as many as 10 assembly seats in the tribal belt of Bankura, Purulia, West Midnapore and Jhargram.

THE BJP HOLDS ONLY 20 OUT OF 104 SEATS RESERVED FOR TRIBALS IN THE PRESENT JHARKHAND, CHHATTISGARH AND MADHYA PRADESH ASSEMBLIES

It realised that if tribals had to be wooed and won, it has to be on their terms and by espousing their culture and philosophy. The course correction came soon. To those like Hemant Soren, who saw identity politics when Modi made the Tribal Pride Day announcement last November, he had his alibi ready: the 75th year of Indian Independence was an occasion to honour our tribal freedom fighters, who had mostly slipped into oblivion. Union tribal affairs minister Arjun Munda said it was the first time such unsung heroes were getting their due honour. Acknowledging the achievements of 200-odd tribals—artists, sportspeople et al—was part of the statement being made. The ultimate bit of symbolism came when the Modi regime put Droupadi Murmu in Rashtrapati Bhavan—the journey of a shy Adivasi girl from the backward parts of Odisha to India's topmost post was offered as an inspirational tale for everyone in India's tribal communities.

"This celebrates tribal lives and acknowledges the hardships they face to make a mark in society. Inaugurating Birsa statues is a way of paying fleeting respect, bringing oppressed people from the margins to the mainstream is perhaps a more sustainable way of honouring them," says social scientist Prasanta Ray. For now, though, it's all about according tribal heroes that moment in the sun. In keeping with electoral exigencies, there's been a surge of that of late. In July, Modi inaugurated a 30-foot bronze statue of freedom fighter Alluri Sitarama Raju in West Godavari in Andhra Pradesh. Raju, though from the Kshatriya caste, fought the British like Birsa, mobilising oppressed tribals in the famous Rampa Rebellion of the 1920s, and laying down his life at age 27.

The BJP is hardly alone in its adulatory overdrive. Leaders of all stripes are basking in the air of Birsa resurrection. Soren had begun a year ago, spending Rs 35 crore to build a Birsa museum, oddly choosing to echo the structure of the infamous Cellular Jail in the Andamans. A 30-foot statue followed, so did a Birsa Memorial Park and 10 statues of other tribal martyrs.

Neighbouring Bengal too is overflowing with Birsa devotion. Mamata inaugurated a statue in Belpahari, Jhargram, and had a 16-ft fibreglass Birsa unveiled virtually in Bankura, on November 15—the second in the vicinity of an anonymous tribal hunter's statue that Union home minister Amit Shah had erroneously garlanded in 2020. While the state BJP held rallies, the CM was seen matching steps with Adivasi women to the beats of drums and timbrels. It might as well have been a quasi-official poll notification: rural body elections are due early 2023. Besides the tribal vote that will be key all over the western and northern belt, it helps thwart a relapse into Maoism.

VOTE FOR DHAMSA MADOL

Madhya Pradesh, even after the demarcation of Chhattisgarh, has a sizeable 21 per cent tribal population. It's not for nothing that CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan too is going around drumming up support, quite literally, with the Adivasi dhamsa-madol. Having burnt his fingers with a tribal backlash in 2018, he's leaving nothing to chance. So President Murmu was at hand on November 15 in Shahdol to launch a big ticket pro-tribal policy—formulation of rules for implementing PESA (Panchayat Extension to Scheduled Areas). Ironically, the rules are being drawn 26 years *after* the PESA Act—largely because neither the BJP nor the Congress wanted to antagonise the OBC votebank. But times have changed.

Birsa had once prophesied his own resurrection, but it's coming true in unpredicted ways. The BJP, which holds 31 of total 47 Lok Sabha seats reserved for tribals, as columnist Mohit Ray points out, wants to thwart any attrition as its rivals home in on the same turf. Sadly, the status quo is too resilient on one front—"The leaders amass wealth, the tribals stay neglected." ■